PREFACE

"The state of Israel will prove itself not by material wealth, not by military might or technical achievement, but by its moral character and human values."

David Ben-Gurion

The soldier, a young Israeli conscript, fired a single bullet into the head of the young Palestinian lying supine on the ground. The killing was hardly the worst thing to happen in greater Israel over the past few years—it was just one death among thousands. Yet that single bullet would shake an entire government and bring down the most powerful man in Israel's military. If you want to understand the seismic changes taking place in Israeli society, it is a good place to start.

It was Purim, March 2016, a Jewish holiday that commemorates the deliverance of the Jews from Haman, a cruel vizier of the Persian Empire. Some describe this holiday as the Jewish Mardi Gras, which many Israelis celebrate by wearing costumes and feasting. It is marked by public readings of the *Megillah*, or the book of Esther—the young Jewish woman and queen of Persia who saved the Jews by exposing Haman's plot to kill them.

It has a particularly dark history in Hebron because it was on Purim in 1994 that Baruch Goldstein, a US-born Israeli immigrant, went on a shooting rampage. A former physician for the Israeli army, he killed twenty-nine Palestinians and wounded 125 more inside the Cave of the Patriarchs (known to Muslims as the Ibrahimi Mosque). The alleys near the mosque are still lined with faded posters bearing the faces of the victims.

Hebron is the largest city in the occupied West Bank, and about 80 per cent—known as H1—is under full Palestinian control. The rest of it—H2—is controlled by the Israeli military, because it is home to about 800 Israeli settlers, who live under heavy guard among 35,000 Palestinians. It is the only place in the West Bank where the two populations live cheek-by-jowl, the place where Israel's half-century occupation appears in starkest relief. Around the time of the shooting, it had also become a focal point for the "lone wolf *intifada*", an outbreak of Palestinian attacks across the Holy